

User Experience Research Proposal

Upstate Underdog Rescue

Star Olaojo, CJ Marino, Ben Froling, Jacob Hebbel, Alan Aguilera

Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute

9/22/2025

Introduction

Upstate Underdog Rescue's website suffers from usability challenges, which reduce engagement. There are many pain points in the user experience, including dense text, confusing navigation, unclear calls-to-action, and broken donation forms. This project will redesign the website to improve usability, normalize information architecture, and make the site easier and intuitive to use. Through user research and testing, the team will identify barriers and prototype improvements, creating actionable recommendations that make the website more intuitive, credible, and supportive of UUR's mission.

Organisation Details

Upstate Underdog Rescue is a nonprofit organization dedicated to saving the lives of at-risk dogs in the capital region of NY. Their mission is to reduce shelter euthanasia rates by properly training dogs and moving them into loving foster homes for successful adoptions. Located locally in downtown Troy, this nonprofit is helping the overburdened local shelters with their most challenging dogs and pairing them with families that will give the overlooked dogs a second chance.

Problem Statement

The current website struggles to achieve social outreach because of its text-heavy, poorly structured, and visually outdated design. The website lacks clear navigation and highlights calls to action for its key audiences: adopters, fosters, volunteers, and donors, but leaves them with no path to navigate forward. Important features such as viewing adoptable dogs, submitting foster applications, or donating are buried under long paragraphs, broken links, and its checkout system is non-functional. Donating and shopping are the most challenging features of the website,

causing missed opportunities to digitally accrue funds from the public. These architectural and usability flaws reduce engagement, limit donations, and ultimately constrain the organization's ability to save dogs. They also lack key social outreach methods like Instagram and TikTok, making it hard for them to reach their target demographic.

Research Methods

The team will employ a mixed-methods research design to help UUR facilitate and simplify the user's understanding of what it takes to adopt one of their dogs. The approach follows the Double Diamond framework (Discover, Define, Develop, Deliver).

First, the team will conduct one-on-one client interviews with Upstate Underdog Rescue leadership and volunteers to understand business goals, constraints, technical infrastructure, and current website performance. These interviews will collect qualitative information as well as the website's utility for each individual. The team will observe how users navigate the page to learn more about barriers and expectations. Surveys to collect broader perceptions, trust signals, and motivations will also be conducted.

To build a holistic mental model around users, Card Sorting and Tree Testing will be implemented. This data prioritizes a website that aligns with a user's expectations and desires. Additionally, this will provide important quantitative data to contextualize user opinions. Further task-based research methods like Usability Testing will be used to gauge how changes made to the site have a positive or negative effect on the user experience. These effects will be measured with task success rate, time on task, error rate, and subjective satisfaction. By combining quantitative and qualitative metrics, the team aims to develop a total understanding of the user experience.

Technical Requirements and Constraints

The updated website needs to be accessible on desktop and mobile devices, ADA-compliant, and run on an affordable, easily maintained platform. Donation processing must be safe, PCI-compliant, and integrated with Shopify. Even with heavy traffic during campaigns, website performance should prioritize dependable uptime and quick load times. The primary constraints are limited client technical skills, the need for straightforward content administration, and the need for less ongoing maintenance. The design must adhere to UUR's branding guidelines, operate within nonprofit budget constraints, and use free or low-cost resources wherever possible. Deliverables for social media must be created with the target demographic in mind and tailored to Instagram's platform requirements (picture ratios, caption restrictions).

Timeline

Discovery Phase (9/22 - 10/13): Meet with UUR to establish priorities, gather initial requirements, identify the website theme, curate a color palette, conduct scripted usability studies, and begin Shopify storefront setup and discussions on the donation pathway redesign.

Analysis Phase (10/13 - 10/27): Analyze data, build user stories, and map navigation in Figma. Plan donation system structure and Instagram launch strategy.

Iterative Development (10/27 - 11/24): Weekly cycles of prototyping in Figma, usability testing, and refinement. Build and integrate a Shopify storefront, implement a donation pathway, and prepare Instagram with initial content.

Build and Deploy MVP (11/24 - 12/8): Deploy redesigned website, integrated storefront, and donation system. Train UUR staff to manage the website and Instagram for long-term sustainability.

Team Roles

Star Olajojo serves as both the project manager and client liaison for Upstate Underdog Rescue. As project manager, she assigns tasks, sets deadlines, and ensures the team stays on track to meet milestones. In her role as client liaison, she is the main contact for the organization, translating client needs into clear actions, addressing feedback, and maintaining open communication. By balancing these responsibilities, she keeps the project organized, builds trust with the client, and helps deliver solutions that meet or exceed expectations.

Ben serves as the design lead, guiding the overall look and feel of the deliverable website. He ensures the website's motif is consistent and visually engaging, aligning with the imagery and purpose of Upstate Underdog Rescue. His role includes assisting with color selection and making key thematic decisions to strengthen the design identity.

Jacob is responsible for documenting the design process. Beyond keeping a written record of methods, results, and analysis, Jacob will ensure this record remains accessible and organized such that referencing it is simple. Additionally, Jacob's ability to document will be critical to providing clear insights from research analysis and ultimately guide the development process.

Alan is the content and social media specialist. He creates posts, captions, and visuals that highlight UUR's mission and connect with its audience. He manages the launch of the Instagram account, making sure content is clear, consistent, and appealing to the right demographic. He also writes calls-to-action for donations and adoptions, keeps branding consistent across the website and social media, and tracks engagement to improve future posts.

CJ is responsible for transforming the team's research and design work into a functional, user-friendly website. He implements prototypes into responsive, accessible code and ensures

that all technical features—such as navigation, forms, donation systems, and adoptable dog listings—perform reliably across devices. By bridging design and functionality, the web developer ensures the final product is both technically sound and aligned with the rescue’s mission.

Deliverables

This project will grow Upstate Underdog Rescue’s online presence and get community engagement through several key deliverables. A Shopify storefront will be added to allow merchandise sales and create a new form of donations. The website will be improved with a redesigned donation pathway and a secure, user-friendly donation system. To expand outreach, an Instagram account will be launched to engage the target audience and raise awareness of UUR’s mission. A complete website redesign will be done in Figma and implemented to allow better user experiences and improved access to donations and other means of support. Training will also be provided for UUR staff so that after the website and social media platform have been handed back to them, there is a seamless transition in their operation.